CHAPTER FOUR

The Doorbell

I glance at the clock. She is late. Tina.

I check. A silhouette stands on the other side of the frosted-glass panel of the old wooden door. I twist the cold brass doorknob. There stands Tina, her eyes smiling through fogged-up glasses, morning rainwater trickling down her hair onto her canvas windbreaker.

"Hi," she says.

I smile back. "I didn't hear you ring the bell. Please, do come in." I direct her into the warmth of the room.

She hesitates at the doorway, apologises for her wet shoes, and asks if she should remove them first.

"Wet shoes are welcome here," I say, closing the door to the cold autumn air behind us. "Come in."

I sweep my palm over the gas-fired heater as we take our seats.

"Should I send you soft copies of these?" she asks, reaching into her rucksack and producing a cardboard folder stuffed with medical records, diagnostic evaluations, and proof of residency. The psychiatric assessments, verified with a stamp on each page, tell me she has been diagnosed with OCD. Reading them through, I still know nothing more about the young person sitting in the room.

Tina is new to this city. She arrived here alone straight out of a university in Asia. She hopes that taking on this poorly paid position—"not enough to survive in this city"—will improve her chances of getting into a good American graduate school. Her parents, themselves sceptical of medication, did not allow her to take it. She tells me, "I tell my parents everything."

I listen, jotting her words into my notepad word-for-word, the way I always do. I become aware of being touched by homesickness. Having grown up in Singapore, I am familiar with elements of her culture. Tina's arrival in this room reminds me that I am also a stranger here. I am surprised at this feeling since I have lived and worked here for fifteen years. Never during this time have I felt the desire to return to Asia. I have become accustomed to thriving as the outsider. The air feels both soothing and unsettling this morning.

"But they don't know that I'm coming to therapy here," Tina continues.

What the Diagnosis Cannot Hold

"My head is aching," she says.

"Tell me something about that."

"My head aches all the time." She rolls her eyes. "I'm always on the screen. My eyes are burning. I'm working, I'm searching all the time... I Google everything."

"Everything," I echo.

"Yes. Before coming here, I Googled about everything, even about going to the supermarket."

"What you're saying resonates with me," I say. "I, too, feel more at ease when I know what to expect. I wonder what happens when you cannot Google the information?"

"My mind starts to think of all probabilities and permutations, and I cannot sleep." Her eyes are wide, agitated, her head tilts as she gestures.

"Probabilities and permutations," I repeat. I cannot help but be tickled by that phrase.

We gaze at each other as if something absurd has just befallen us. She repeats, “Yes, probabilities and permutations.”

We laugh.

“I gather that in thinking so, you avoid... what? Things from happening? Bad things, perhaps?” I ask.

“Yeah. If I don’t think about it, it will happen.”

That sounds like quite a bit of material to think through.

“Like I’m trying to push a wall with my mind.”

“How did you expect this morning’s session to turn out?”

“I was actually very early,” she says, tightening both arms around the rucksack resting on her lap. She recounts how she memorised the subway map and rehearsed her route to my office. “I waited outside the building. Then I saw your name on the buzzer. Then I waited.”

Waited?

“Because I wasn’t sure.”

“What weren’t you sure of?” I ask.

“I wasn’t sure if ringing the bell was the right thing to do.”

There.

She stood in the rain outside my office, having memorised the route, having arrived early, having prepared, and she hesitated to press the buzzer. Shame did not allow her to act. Her mind offered many reasons for stalling her. One of them: *If I announce myself, I will annoy someone.*

Tina’s doorbell embodied the fear of being sensed. I pick up this shame-protecting mechanism, which

showed up within the first ten minutes of our meeting. It is familiar to me.

The Shame Paradox

Why We Fear Most the Emotion That Keeps Us Human

Nicole Chew-Helbig



nicolechewhelbig.com/theshameparadox.html